

Session 4: Longing for God's Kingdom

Key Takeaways

- Jesus explains that those who mourn have the good life because they will be comforted. This mirrors the words of Isaiah 61:2, where comfort is promised to those mourning over Israel's covenant unfaithfulness.
- The first three beatitudes highlight hope for those who are powerless, who grieve over corruption, and who are often overlooked, having no voice or influence. This emphasizes God's focus on the marginalized.
- The second triad of beatitudes highlights the character of people longing to see their world reflect God's heart through right relationships, mercy, and pure hearts.

A Close Reading of the Beatitudes: The Poor in Spirit

Matthew 5:3 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for the poor in spirit,
because theirs is the kingdom of the skies.

Powerless

To be "poor in spirit" (οἱ πτωχοὶ τῷ πνεύματι) means to be powerless.

1. "Spirit" (πνεύμα) here has its Hebrew meaning (*ruakh* / רוח) of a person's inner vitality and energy, that comes as a gift from God (and can be taken away by God).

Job 12:10 Instructor's Translation

In God's hand is the **life-being** (*nephesh*) of every creature,
and the ***ruakh*** of all humanity.

Genesis 7:15 NASB

So they went into the ark to Noah, by twos of all flesh in which was **the breath of life**.

Job 17:1 NASB

My spirit is broken, my days are extinguished, the grave is ready for me.

2. In Hebrew, to say someone is "X of spirit" is to describe the quality of their life-vitality or life-energy.

- Psalm 34:18 "crushed of spirit" means the life energy is crushed and diminished
- Job 7:11 "distressed of spirit" means his life-energy is under duress, squeezed

- Genesis 26:35 “bitter of spirit” (מרת רוח) means sour, bitter in one’s vital energy
- Isaiah 54:6 “pained of spirit” (עצובת רוח) means one’s vital energy is in distress, cut short
- Ezekiel 3:14 “bitter and hot of spirit” means sour and angry
- Proverbs 15:4 “broken of spirit” (שבר רוח) means one’s energy is broken, drained

3. To be “poor in spirit” means to be impoverished of energy and vitality. Our word “**powerless**” would be a good translation. “Poor” (Greek: *ptokhos*) means those without economic stability or security, dependent on others.

Matthew 19:21 NASB

Jesus said to him, “If you wish to be complete, go and **sell your possessions and give to the poor**, and you will have treasure

Mark 12:42 NASB

A poor widow came and put in two small copper coins, which amount to a cent.

Luke 16:20–21 NASB

And a **poor** man named Lazarus was laid at his gate, covered with sores, and longing to be fed with the crumbs which were falling from the rich man’s table; besides, even the dogs were coming and licking his sores.

The Greek word *ptokos* is one of the standard Septuagint translations of the Hebrew word ‘*aniy* (עני), which refers to low social status, someone who is looked down upon by those in powerful social roles. Their low status is often a result of poverty, though not always.

Amos 2:6-7 Instructor's Translation

For three sins of Israel, even for four,
I will not turn back its punishment,
because they sell the innocent for silver,
and the **needy** (‘*evyon*) for a pair of sandals.
They trample on the heads of the **poor** (*dal*) as on the dust of the ground
and deny justice to the ‘**anivim**.

4. “ ... of spirit.”

Jesus is here adopting language from Isaiah and Proverbs to describe the “poor” and powerless among the low social status in Israelite society. These are people of low social status, unable to change their circumstances and oppressed by religious and political powers over them.

Isaiah 61:1–3 NASB

The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me,
because the LORD has anointed me
to bring good news to the afflicted;
he has sent me to bind up **the broken of heart**,
to proclaim liberty to captives and freedom to prisoners;
to proclaim the favorable year of the LORD

and the day of vengeance of our God;
to comfort all who mourn,
to grant those who mourn in Zion,
giving them a garland instead of ashes,
the oil of **gladness instead of mourning,**
the mantle of praise instead of **a spirit of fainting.**
So they will be called oaks of righteousness,
the planting of the LORD, that he may be glorified.

Isaiah 66:1-2 Instructor's Translation

Thus says the LORD,
"Heaven is my throne and the earth is my footstool.
Where then is a house you could build for me?
And where is a place that I may rest?
For my hand made all these things,
thus all these things came into being," declares the LORD.
"But to this one I will look,
to him who is **poor and broken of spirit,** and who trembles at my word.

Proverbs 16:19 Instructor's Translation

It is better to be **low of spirit with the poor** than to divide the spoil with the proud.

Jesus is adopting the language of Isaiah 61 that was also adopted by the Dead Sea sect, to describe their own sectarian identity in contrast to their Israelite kinsmen. In the Qumran hymnbook (1QHodayot-a, 23:14-15), the poet describes himself as a herald to their group.

a herald [...] of your goodness, to proclaim **to the poor** the abundance of your compassion, [...] ... from the spring [... **the bro]ken of spirit, and the mourning** to everlasting joy.

ל[היות] כאמתכה מבשר [...] טובכה לבשר ענוים לרוב רחמיכה
ממקור [...] דכ]אי רוח ואבלים לשמחת עולם [...] 15

García Martínez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J. C. (1999). [*The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition \(transcriptions\)*](#). Eerdmans. 198-199.

And in another fragment (4Q521 Frag. 2, col. 2:5-8), we find Isaiah 61 again being used to refer to the apocalyptic hope of the group.

⁵ For the Lord will consider the pious, and call the righteous by name,
⁶ and his spirit will hover upon **the poor**, and he will renew the faithful with his strength.
⁷ For he will honour the pious upon the throne of an eternal kingdom,
⁸ freeing prisoners, giving sight to **the blind**, straightening out the twis[ted.]
⁵ כי אדני חסידים יבקר וצדיקים בשם יקרא
⁶ ועל ענוים רוחו תרחף ואמונים יחליף בכחו
⁷ כי יכבד את חסידים על כסא מלכות עד
⁸ מתיר אסורים פוקח עורים זוקף כ[פופים]

García Martínez, Florentino & Tigchelaar, Eibert J. C. (1999). [*The Dead Sea Scrolls Study Edition \(transcriptions\)*](#). Eerdmans. 1044-1045.

“It must be stressed that the religious meaning of ‘poor’ does not exclude the economic meaning. Rather, the two go together. With probably the majority of Jesus’ audience, the religious state of poverty was matched by an outward condition: they suffered literal poverty and experienced first-hand economic inequities. They knew the meaning of need because they were poor in spirit and poor in fact.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2000). [*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel According to Saint Matthew, vol. 3 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark. 443.

Scot McKnight points out that “poor in spirit” means an economically, physically impoverished or oppressed person who not only recognizes her or his need but also trusts in God for full redemption.

- Luke only has “poor” in [Luke 6:20](#). You have to say that Matthew has “spiritualized” the saying or that Jesus meant two different things. Is “spirit” an adverb, leading to “spiritually poor,” recognizing your spiritual poverty?
- Jesus didn’t separate physical and spiritual poverty. He saw them as linked. In both cases, circumstances compel people to see their need for God. Also, we have to remember Jesus’ actual historical setting: mostly lower class Jewish farmers, fishermen, and traders, scraping by under the harsh economy of Roman rule. The only wealthy Jews were ones who were aligned with Rome, and so spiritual and economic poverty went hand in hand in the Galilee of Jesus’ day.

“... Because theirs is the kingdom” (lit. “of them is the kingdom”)

- This doesn’t mean that it belongs exclusively to them. Rather, these “because” statements communicate the reversal. These powerless folks, who would normally never be associated with God’s heavenly power are, in fact, the first ones to be receiving Jesus’ announcement of the arrival of God’s reign on Earth as in Heaven.
- The outcome of the final judgment is brought here and now into the present. The poor will be given the Kingdom, to the surprise of all those who thought it actually belonged to them.

Those Who Mourn

Matthew 5:4 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for those who grieve,
because they will be comforted.

“To grieve” (Greek: *pentheo*, to mourn, cry with grief) is the standard biblical word for public displays of mourning and grief when one has suffered loss, usually death.

Genesis 23:1–2 Instructor's Translation

Sarah lived to be a hundred and twenty-seven years old. She **died** at Kiriath Arba (that is, Hebron) in the land of Canaan, and Abraham went to **mourn** for Sarah and to **weep** over her.

Genesis 37:33–35 NIV

Jacob recognized it and said, "It is my son's robe! Some ferocious animal has devoured him. Joseph has surely been torn to pieces."

Then Jacob tore his clothes, put on sackcloth and **mourned** for his son many days.

All his sons and daughters came to comfort him, but **he refused to be comforted**. "No," he said, "I will continue to mourn until I join my son in the grave." So his father wept for him.

Genesis 50:3-4, 10 NASB

³ Now forty days were required for it, for such is the period required for embalming. And the Egyptians **wept for him seventy days**.

⁴ When **the days of mourning** for him were past, Joseph spoke to the household of Pharaoh, saying, "If now I have found favor in your sight, please speak to Pharaoh, saying ..."

¹⁰ When they came to the threshing floor of Atad, which is beyond the Jordan, they lamented there with **a very great and sorrowful lamentation; and he observed seven days mourning for his father**.

Jacob's mourners

These stories of personal grief become paradigms for the Israelites who lived through the devastation of exile, a condition that continued on into the Second Temple period under persecution from tyrants without and corrupt Israelite leaders within. Their voices are heard all over the Psalms and Prophets.

Isaiah 61:1-3 NASB

The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me,
Because the LORD has anointed me
to bring good news to the afflicted;
he has sent me to bind up **the broken of heart**,
to proclaim liberty to captives and freedom to prisoners;
to proclaim the favorable year of the LORD
and the day of vengeance of our God;
to comfort all who mourn,
to grant those who mourn in Zion,
giving them a garland instead of ashes,
the oil of **gladness instead of mourning**,
the mantle of praise instead of **a spirit of fainting**.
So they will be called oaks of righteousness,
The planting of the LORD, that he may be glorified.

Isaiah 66:1-2 Instructor's Translation

Thus says the Lord,
"Heaven is my throne and the earth is my footstool.
Where then is a house you could build for me?
And where is a place that I may rest?
For my hand made all these things,
thus all these things came into being," declares the Lord.

“But to this one I will look,
to him who is **poor and broken of spirit**, and who trembles at my word.

Ezra 10:6 NIV

Then Ezra withdrew from before the house of God and went to the room of Jehohanan son of Eliashib. While he was there, he ate no food and drank no water, because he continued to **mourn over the unfaithfulness of the exiles**.

Nehemiah 1:3–4 NIV

They said to me, “Those who survived the exile and are back in the province are in great trouble and disgrace. **The wall of Jerusalem is broken down**, and its gates have been burned with fire.” When I heard these things, I sat down and wept. For some days I **mourned** and fasted and prayed before the God of heaven.

“God’s own are on the bottom, the wicked on the top. So mourning is heard because the righteous suffer, because the wicked prosper, and because God has not yet acted to reverse the situation. ... The people of God have yet to see the kingdom of God in its fullness. They are persecuted, and God’s will is not done on earth as it is in heaven. The righteous cannot but mourn until the eschatological reversal; it is not possible to be content with the status quo. To those who understand the truth about the present age, grief cannot be eliminated; it is, in fact, accentuated.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2000). [*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel According to Saint Matthew, vol. 3 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark. 448.

The Afflicted/Unimportant

Matthew 5:5 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for the unimportant,
because they will inherit the land.

Two important notes for understanding this saying:

1. The Greek word *praus* (πραυς) is one of the common ways the Greek Septuagint translated the Hebrew word *‘aniy* / עֲנִי, which means the “poor and afflicted.” In other words, this word is a close synonym with “poor in spirit.”
- To translate this word as “meek” or “humble” is misleading. A survey of this Greek word in the Old Testament makes this clear.

Psalms 76:8–9 NASB

You caused judgment to be heard from heaven; the earth feared and was still when God arose to judgment, to save all the **afflicted** (עֲנִי / πρᾶυς) of the earth.
Selah.

Psalms 147:6 NASB

The Lord supports the **afflicted** (עני / πρᾶνς); he brings down the wicked to the ground.

Job 24:3-4 NASB

They drive away the donkeys of the orphans;
they take the widow's ox for a pledge.
They push the needy aside from the road;
the **afflicted** (עני / πρᾶνς) of the land are made to hide themselves altogether.

Job 36:15 NASB

He delivers the **afflicted** (עני / πρᾶνς) in their affliction, and opens their ear in time of oppression.

Isaiah 26:5-6 NASB

For he has brought low those who dwell on high, the unassailable city;
he lays it low, he lays it low to the ground,
he casts it to the dust.
The foot will trample it, the feet of the **afflicted** (עני / πρᾶνς), the steps of the helpless.

2. Jesus is adopting the language of Psalm 37:11 here, which paints the portrait of “the afflicted” in clear terms. Psalm 37 is itself linked to a whole network of “afflicted” poems in the Psalms scroll. In these texts, we hear the voices of those who gave the Hebrew Bible its final shape, a persecuted, ethnic-religious minority in Jerusalem who hoped in God and suffered at the hands of imperial occupiers.

Psalm 37:7-11 NIV*

Be still before the LORD and wait patiently for him;
do not fret when people succeed in their ways,
when they carry out their wicked schemes.
Refrain from anger and turn from hot anger; do not fret—it leads only to bad.
For those who are **evil will be destroyed,**
but **those who hope in Yahweh they will inherit the land.**
A little while, and **the wicked** will be no more;
though you look for them, they will not be found.
But **the ‘any will inherit the land** and enjoy *shalom* and *tov*.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 76:8-9 NIV

From heaven you pronounced judgment, and the land feared and was quiet—
when you, God, rose up to judge, **to save all the afflicted of the land.**

Psalm 147:2-6 NIV

The LORD builds up Jerusalem; he gathers **the exiles of Israel.**
He heals **the brokenhearted** and binds up their wounds.
He determines the number of the stars and calls them each by name.
Great is our Lord and mighty in power; his understanding has no limit.
The LORD sustains **the afflicted** but casts the wicked to the ground.

Psalm 149:2-4 NIV

Let Israel rejoice in their Maker; let the people of Zion be glad in their King.
Let them praise his name with dancing and make music to him with timbrel and harp.
For the LORD takes delight in his people; he crowns **the afflicted** with victory.

The “afflicted poor” are non-influential people, those deemed unimportant. There are two ways that “meek” has been interpreted.

1. Those who think of themselves as unimportant = meek, unassuming, not overly self-important. This is what most modern English translations assume. This comes from a handful of uses of the word *‘aniy* where it can describe someone who doesn’t act like they’re influential.

Numbers 12:1-3 NASB

Then Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses because of the Cushite woman whom he had married (for he had married a Cushite woman);
and they said, “Has the Lord indeed spoken only through Moses? Has he not spoken through us as well?”
And the Lord heard it.
(Now the man **Moses was very ‘aniy**, more than any man who was on the face of the land.)

2. Those who are treated as unimportant by others = the afflicted-poor: This makes sense of the second clause (“they will inherit the land”). These are people who don’t demand or have the ability to demand that they be taken seriously or that they be noticed; these are the neglected and overlooked and those taken advantage of.

“ ... because they will inherit the land” (Ps. 37:11, 22, 34)

Psalm 37:10-11 NIV

A little while, and the wicked will be no more; though you look for them, they will not be found. But **the afflicted will inherit the land** and enjoy peace and prosperity.

Psalm 37:21-22 NIV

The wicked borrow and do not repay, but the righteous give generously;
those the Lord blesses will inherit the land, but those he curses will be destroyed.

Psalm 37:34 NIV

Hope in the Lord and keep his way.
He will exalt you to inherit the land; when the wicked are destroyed, you will see it.

Jesus is speaking in very real terms here to Galilean Jews and impoverished people who don’t own any land or whose ancestral lands have been taken from them. While the Romans are in charge, seizing land right and left, land means land.

Summary 1st-3rd Beatitudes

How good is life for the powerless who grieve over the corrupt and ruined state of Israel, who are often overlooked and taken advantage of, and who have no voice or influence. God’s Kingdom, which has arrived

here on earth in the mission of Jesus, belongs first and foremost to them and offers a promise of comfort and a future Eden blessing when all things are made right.

Those Hungry for Justice

Matthew 5:6 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for those who hunger and thirst for right-relationships, because they will be satisfied.

What does “righteousness” (Greek: δικαιοσύνη) mean here? There are a few compelling options for the particular nuance of meaning here.

Defining Righteousness: Nuance 1

Acting in ways that are “right/appropriate” to a specific relationship; relational actions that align with God’s ideal vision for human relationships. This equals “doing right by each other.” This is a standard meaning of “righteousness” in the Hebrew Bible and New Testament.

Jeremiah 22:3 NIV

This is what the LORD says: **Do justice and righteousness.** Rescue from the hand of the oppressor the one who has been robbed. Do no wrong or violence to the foreigner, the fatherless or the widow, and do not shed innocent blood in this place.

Deuteronomy 24:10–13 NASB

When you make your neighbor a loan of any sort, you shall not enter his house to take his pledge. You shall remain outside, and the man to whom you make the loan shall bring the pledge out to you. If he is a poor man, you shall not sleep with his pledge.

When the sun goes down you shall surely return the pledge to him, that he may sleep in his cloak and bless you; and **it will be your righteousness**, before the Lord your God.

Proverbs 11:4–6 NASB

Riches do not profit in the day of wrath,
but **righteousness** delivers from death.

The **righteousness** of the blameless will smooth his way,
but the wicked will fall by his own wickedness.

The **righteousness** of the upright will deliver them,
but the treacherous will be caught by their own greed.

Psalms 11:7 NIV

For the LORD is **righteous, he loves righteousness**; the upright will see his face.

Matthew 5:20 NIV

For I tell you that unless **your righteousness** surpasses that of the Pharisees and the teachers of the law, you will certainly not enter the kingdom of heaven.

Nuance 1 is by far the most dominant meaning of “righteousness” in Matthew.

Matthew 3:15 NASB

But Jesus answering said to [John the immerser], “Permit it at this time; for in this way it is fitting for us to **fulfill all righteousness.**” Then he permitted him.

Jesus sees his baptism as a necessary act of “doing right by God and neighbor,” specifically, his act of identifying in solidarity with sinful Israel, which needs a ritual cleansing to prepare for God’s new creation act of salvation.

Matthew 5:10 NASB

Blessed are those who have been persecuted for the sake of **righteousness**, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Matthew 5:20 NASB

For I say to you that unless your **righteousness** surpasses that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will not enter the kingdom of heaven.

Matthew 6:1 NASB

Beware of practicing **your righteousness** before men to be noticed by them; otherwise you have no reward with your Father who is in heaven.

Matthew 6:33 NASB

But seek first his kingdom and **his righteousness**, and all these things will be added to you.

Matthew 21:32 NASB

For John came to you in **the way of righteousness** and you did not believe him; but the tax collectors and prostitutes did believe him; and you, seeing this, did not even feel remorse afterward so as to believe him.

In favor of nuance 1 (“humans doing right by God and each other”) is [Matthew 5:10](#) in the immediate context (“How good is life for those who are persecuted for the sake of righteousness”), which assumes the right conduct is something these disciples are already doing and are persecuted for.

Defining Righteousness: Nuance 2

“God’s actions by which he does right by his human covenant partners, proving true to his character and promise.”

Psalms 31:1 NASB

In you, O Lord, I have taken refuge; let me never be ashamed;
in your righteousness deliver me.

Psalms 103:6 NASB*

The Lord performs **righteous acts (lit. “righteousnesses”)** and judgments for all who are oppressed.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 24:3-5 NASB

Who may ascend into the hill of the Lord? And who may stand in his holy place?

He who has clean hands and a pure heart, who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood and has not sworn deceitfully.

He shall receive a blessing from the Lord
and **righteousness** from the God of his salvation.

Psalm 24:5, “to receive ... righteousness from the God of salvation,” means that in the final judgment (or earlier, one could hope) one can expect that God will “do right by you” by declaring you to “be in the right,” over against anyone else’s evaluation of you (like the Satan’s) because of one’s own righteous deeds.

When God “declares righteous,” it is God “doing right by” his promises and bringing the great reversal. Two examples are Simeon and Anna, who longed to see the age of the messiah come.

Defining Righteousness: Nuance 3

A combination of the above two: “a longing for humans to fulfill God’s will for their conduct as well as to see God fulfill his own promises in bringing justice and reversal.” (Manson, T.W. [*Sayings of Jesus*](#), 48)

Isaiah 56:1 NIV*

This is what the Lord says:

“Maintain justice and do **righteousness [nuance 1]**,
for my deliverance is close at hand
and **my righteousness [nuance 2]** will soon be revealed.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“They will be satisfied”: Divine passive, “by God.” How and with what these are “filled up” is not clarified. They will be filled by the messianic banquet (cf. [*Isa. 25:6-8*](#)).

Conclusion: “To hunger and thirst for righteousness” means that one looks out at the world and longs to see justice and peace [nuance 1], and is in a constant state of dissatisfaction when there is injustice. It also means that one lives in deep longing and anticipation of the time when God brings ultimate justice on human evil and sets things right once and for all [nuance 2].

The Merciful

Matthew 5:7 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for those who show mercy,
for they will be shown mercy.

The Greek word *eleos* is a common way the Greek Septuagint translated the Hebrew words *khesed*, “loyal love,” as well as *khanan*, “to show favor, grace.”

Jesus uses this word often in his teachings on forgiveness and generosity, but it’s clear that he also incorporates the nuance of “loyal-love to Israel’s God” as well.

The conclusion to the parable of the ungrateful servant who wouldn’t forgive one who owed him little.

Matthew 18:32–33 NASB

Then summoning him, his lord said to him, “You wicked slave, I forgave you all that debt because you pleaded with me.

Should you not also have **shown** mercy to your fellow slave, in the same way that I **showed** mercy to you?”

Matthew 23:23 niv

Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You give a tenth of your spices—mint, dill and cumin. But you have neglected the more important matters of the law—justice, **mercy** and faithfulness. You should have practiced the latter, without neglecting the former.

In Matthew, “mercy” is not just forgiveness but any act of kindness, generosity, or service meant for another’s benefit. Jesus is regularly called upon to show mercy, and he always does.

Matthew 9:27 NASB

As Jesus went on from there, two blind men followed him, crying out, “**Have mercy on us**, Son of David!”

Matthew 15:22 NASB

And a Canaanite woman from that region came out and began to cry out, saying, “**Have mercy on me**, Lord, Son of David; my daughter is cruelly demon-possessed.”

Matthew 17:15 NASB

“Lord, **have mercy on my son**, for he is a lunatic and is very ill; for he often falls into the fire and often into the water.

Jesus doesn’t have an existing relationship with these people, but they can, as fellow Israelites, make a request that he show them kindness and address their terrible circumstances.

Jesus explained his own emphasis on forgiveness and generosity to outsiders by appealing to the word *eleos* rooted in the Hebrew Scriptures.

Matthew 9:11–13 NASB

When the Pharisees saw this, they said to his disciples, “Why is your Teacher eating with the tax collectors and sinners?”

But when Jesus heard this, he said,

“It is not those who are healthy who need a physician, but those who are sick. But go and learn what this means:

‘I desire *e/leos*, and not sacrifice,’
for I did not come to call the **righteous**, but sinners.”

“ἔλεος connotes the idea of loyalty within a relationship. (Matt. 9:13 and 12:7 cite Hosea 6:6, in which *hesed* = ἔλεος clearly involves covenant loyalty.) Hence, it would seem, the evangelist was persuaded that while Jesus and his followers, in their acts of mercy and loving-kindness, were demonstrating their loyalty to God ... ‘Justice and mercy and faith’—these were ‘the weightier matters of the law’ neglected by Matthew’s opponents. ... Throughout Matthew (including 5:7) ‘mercy’ and its cognates imply that merciful action is the concrete expression of loyalty to God, and that what God demands is not so much activity directed Godward (‘I desire ... not sacrifice’), but loving-kindness benefiting other people.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (1988). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark. 455.

The Pure in Heart

Matthew 5:8 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for the pure in heart,
for they will see God.

The phrase “X of heart” (similarly to “X of spirit”) marks a quality or character of the person’s mind, will, and center of thought and feeling:

- [Psalm 90:12](#) “heart of wisdom” = a wise heart, wisdom at the core of one’s being
- [2 Chronicles 29:34](#) “upright of heart” = people of integrity, principled
- [Psalm 109:16](#) “broken of heart” = someone whose mind and will have been diminished, not functioning rightly due to suffering or pain
- [Psalm 24:4](#) and [73:1](#) “pure of heart” = someone whose mind, will, and desire have been purged of all other influences and are purely dedicated to God

The idea of the “pure of heart seeing God” is an allusion to a network of psalms that explore a key idea from the Hebrew Bible: the return to Eden where one can gaze upon the divine glory and beauty.

Psalm 24:3–6 NASB

Who may ascend into the hill of the LORD?

And who may stand in his holy place?

He who has clean hands and **a pure heart** (בר לבב / καθαρός τῇ καρδίᾳ),

who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood

and has not sworn deceitfully.

He shall receive a blessing from the LORD

and righteousness from the God of his salvation.

⁶ This is the generation of those who seek him,

who seek Your face—even Jacob.

Selah.

Psalm 51:10 NIV

Create in me **a pure heart**, O God, and renew a steadfast spirit within me.

Psalm 73:1 NASB

Surely God is good to Israel, to those who are **pure in heart!**

“Pure” (בר) is from בָּרַר, “to purify, clean, purge from impurities” and metaphorically, “to select, choose.”

Isaiah 52:11 NASB

Depart, depart, go out from there,
touch nothing unclean;
go out of the midst of her, **purify** yourselves,
you who carry the vessels of the LORD.

Jeremiah 4:11 NASB

In that time it will be said to this people and to Jerusalem, “A scorching wind from the bare heights in the wilderness in the direction of the daughter of my people—not to sift and not **to cleanse**,

Ezekiel 20:38 NASB

and I will **purge** from you the rebels and those who transgress against me; I will bring them out of the land where they sojourn, but they will not enter the land of Israel. Thus you will know that I am the LORD.

Daniel 11:35 NASB

Some of those who have insight will fall, in order to refine, **purge** and make them pure until the end time; because it is still to come at the appointed time.

In the Hebrew Bible, “purity of heart” is the result of a long process of sifting through one’s desires, discarding or deprioritizing any desire that does not lead one to the ultimate source of life itself: the creative power and majesty of God’s presence.

“So purity of heart ... involve[s] integrity, a correspondence between outward action and inward thought (cf. 15:8), a lack of duplicity, singleness of intention, and the desire to please God above all else. More succinctly: purity of heart is to will one thing, God’s will, with all of one’s being.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (1988). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark. 456.

The rest of the Sermon on the Mount will fill out the meaning of this phrase: Their heart motivations are sincere. They are not concerned with being seen by others, but rather for a personal connection with the Father. Their greatest values are matters of the heart, not accumulation of wealth and prestige. Their behavior is fully consistent with their inward motives: a lack of duplicity and a desire to please God above all else.

“ ... Because they will see God” is a reference to the vision of God in the heavenly temple, the cosmic Eden. Jesus will later describe how right now, in the present, the heavenly angels see God.

Matthew 18:10 NASB

See that you do not despise one of these little ones, for I say to you that **their angels in heaven continually see the face of my Father who is in heaven.**

This alludes to the tradition of “guardian angels” that is rooted in the biblical traditions of the angel of Yahweh appearing to people in distress (Hagar in Gen. 16, Jacob in Gen. 28, 31-33) and rescuing them (see Ps. 34:7, 9:11). This idea was developed in Second Temple literature so that certain groups of angels were called “angels of the face.” That is, angels who stand in God’s presence and look upon his face (see Tobit 12:15: “I am Raphael, one of the seven angels who stand ready and can enter the glorious presence of the Lord.”) (For discussion, see Dale Allison, *God*, p. 47-50.)

To see God in the temple or in the holy space is a biblical image for a desire to return to Eden, to ascend to the cosmic mountain. This is a common image in the psalms and in the new Eden hope of Isaiah.

Psalm 63:2-3 NIV

I have seen you in the sanctuary and beheld your power and your glory.
Because your love is better than life, my lips will glorify you.

Psalm 27:4 NASB

One thing I have asked from the LORD, that I shall seek:
That I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life,
to behold the beauty of the LORD and to meditate in his temple.

Psalm 11:7 NASB

For the LORD is righteous,
he loves righteousness;
the upright will behold his face.

Psalm 16:8-11 NASB

I have set the LORD continually before me; because he is at my right hand, I will not be shaken.
Therefore my heart is glad and my glory rejoices; my flesh also will dwell securely.
For you will not abandon my soul to Sheol; nor will you allow your Holy One to undergo decay.
You will make known to me the path of life; **with your face is fullness of joy;**
in your right hand there are pleasures forever.

Psalm 17:15 NASB

As for me, I shall behold your face in righteousness; **I will be satisfied with your likeness** when I awake.

Psalm 42:2 NASB

My soul thirsts for God, for the living God; when shall I come and **be seen before God?**

Isaiah 66:18-20 NASB

For I know their works and their thoughts; the time is coming to **gather all nations and tongues. And they shall come and see my glory.**

I will set a sign among them and will send survivors from them to the nations: Tarshish, Put, Lud, Meshech, Tubal and Javan, to the distant coastlands that have neither heard my fame nor seen my glory. And they will declare my glory among the nations.

Then **they shall bring all your brothers from all the nations** as a grain offering to the LORD, on horses, in chariots, in litters, on mules and on camels, **to my holy mountain Jerusalem.**

Summary 4th-6th Beatitudes

How good is life for those who long to see justice and right relationships become the norm in all levels of human society, and who do their part by showing loyalty and generous mercy to others. They live this way because of their pure and genuine desire to experience God's presence and do his will. In due time, God will give them vindication, mercy, and fulfillment of what they most desire.

The Peacemakers

Matthew 5:9 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for the peacemakers,
for they will be called children of God.

There is an important thematic background for peace (Hebrew: *shalom*) in the Hebrew Bible.

In Isaiah 9:6, the messiah is called "Prince of Peace" (שֵׁר שְׁלוֹם). His rule can be described as a new Eden (Isa. 11:1-10). Later in Isaiah, this new Eden is described as an exalted city with "peace like a river" flowing in (Isa. 66:12).

Micah 5:5 Instructor's Translation

This one (the messiah) will be our peace.

The Greek word "peacemaker" (εἰρηνοποιος) appears only here in the New Testament, though Paul uses the verbal form "making peace" to describe how Jesus "reconciled" all creation to himself through the cross (Col. 1:20).

Colossians 1:20 NET

and through him to reconcile all things to himself by **making peace** (εἰρηνοποιήσας) through the blood of his cross, whether things on earth or things in heaven.

The word describes someone who aids in bringing about a condition of peace. They take an active posture toward conflict between others, whether that conflict is between others or with themselves (as Jesus later describes in the sermon, Matt. 5:27-30).

The preceding beatitudes make clear that these surprise-citizens of God's Kingdom live in a world of oppression, injustice, and inequity that bothers them to the core. And if one allows holy discontent to motivate action, the kinds of behaviors generated will be peace-seeking and peace-making.

Jesus is saying these words in a fraught political context. In the 1st century, he and his people lived under Roman occupation. Throughout the 30s-70s, Israelite communities were surging with religious resistance to Rome, though it took different forms:

- Withdrew (Qumran)
- Compromised with Rome (Sadducees)
- Increased their piety and holiness (Pharisees)
- Fought back against Rome (Zealots)

Jesus says the good life belongs to those who neither withdraw nor violently resist. Rather, he speaks of putting yourself in the middle of the conflict, where you could be fired on from both sides, and speak for peace in an attempt to broker peace.

Someone who is at peace with God loves peace and knows that God loves peace. When such a person sees conflict, they put themselves in the middle to help mediate and create peace. Peacemakers do not minimize difference or conflict, but neither do they encourage mere toleration. Rather, they promote loving relationships that create affection and communion across those differences.

The peacemaker brokers to create a venue where forgiveness is possible and creates a new future.

“They will be called sons of God”: Jesus will repeat this idea in [Matthew 5:45](#).

Matthew 5:44–45 NASB

But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,
so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for he causes his sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.

To be “sons of God” is to reflect the likeness of the Father; the familial language highlights membership and participation in the family character. Such people show themselves to be part of God’s own family by their pursuit of peace.

The Persecuted, Part 1

Matthew 5:10 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for those who are persecuted
on account of doing-what-is-right
for theirs is the kingdom of the skies.

Jesus needs to prepare his disciples for the reality of being misunderstood and mistreated. People who make peace, that is, who confront injustice by peaceably placing themselves in the middle of the conflict, pointing out the failures that generate hostile conflict on all sides—such folks should expect resistance in the extreme.

Jesus will later bring up the hostility that his disciples are likely to face as they represent him to Israel.

Matthew 5:44 LEB

But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who **persecute** you,

Matthew 10:23 LEB

And whenever they **persecute** you in this town, flee to another, for truly I say to you, you will never finish going through the towns of Israel until the Son of Man comes.

Jesus will later claim that the hostility of Jerusalem’s leaders against him is part of a long legacy of persecuting prophets.

Matthew 23:34–35 NASB

Therefore, behold, **I am sending you prophets and wise men and scribes**; some of them you will kill and crucify, and some of them you will scourge in your synagogues, and **persecute** from city to city, so that upon you may fall the guilt of all the righteous blood shed on earth, from the blood of righteous Abel to the blood of Zechariah, the son of Berechiah, whom you murdered between the temple and the altar.

Jesus is here appealing to a biblical tradition that began in the Torah and Prophets, focusing on the motif of Israel's disregard and rejection of the prophets who accused them of violating their covenant with Yahweh.

2 Kings 17:13-14 NASB

Yet **the LORD warned Israel and Judah through all his prophets** and every seer, saying, "Turn from your evil ways and keep my commandments, my statutes according to all the law which I commanded your fathers, and which I sent to you through my servants the prophets."

However, **they did not listen**, but stiffened their neck like their fathers, who did not believe in the LORD their God.

2 Chronicles 36:15-16 NASB

The LORD, the God of their fathers, sent word to them again and again by his messengers, because he had compassion on his people and on his dwelling place; but **they continually mocked the messengers of God**, despised his words and scoffed at his prophets, until the wrath of the LORD arose against his people, until there was no remedy.

Nehemiah 9:26 NASB

But they became disobedient and rebelled against you
and cast your law behind their backs
and **killed your prophets** who had admonished them,
so that they might return to you,
and they committed great blasphemies.

The murdered or persecuted prophets in mind here are:

- Jeremiah and Uriah ben Shemaiah (see Jer. 26:20-23)
- Zechariah ben Yehoiadah (2 Chron. 24:20-22)
- The prophets in the days of Elijah (1 Kgs. 18:4)

Peter will later apply this saying of Jesus to the persecuted followers of Jesus in Asia Minor.

1 Peter 3:13-14 LEB

And who is the one who will harm you if you are a zealous adherent for what is good?

But **even if you might suffer for the sake of righteousness, you are blessed (*makarios*)**. And do not be afraid of their intimidation or be disturbed,

The Persecuted, Part 2

Matthew 5:11-12 Instructor's Translation

How good is life for y'all

when people insult you
and persecute you
and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account.

Rejoice and be glad,
for your reward is great in heaven,
for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.

The “insults” (ὀνειδισμός) refer to public defamation and shame brought upon someone. This is a key motif in the Psalms (where ὀνειδίζω often translates חרף), describing David in his wilderness exile. Saul’s “persecution” of David becomes the template for the persecution of the righteous in the Psalms, and so the afflicted ones of the Psalms look to David as their model.

Psalm 42:10 NIV

My bones suffer mortal agony **as my foes taunt me**, saying to me all day long, “Where is your God?”

Psalm 44:15-16 NASB

All day long my **dishonor** is before me
and my **humiliation** has overwhelmed me,
because **of the voice of him who reproaches and reviles**,
because of the presence of **the enemy** and the avenger.

Psalm 69:8-9 NASB

I have become estranged from **my brothers**
and an alien to my mother’s sons.
For zeal for your house has consumed me,
and the **reproaches** of those who **reproach**
you have fallen on me.

Psalm 102:7-8 NASB

I lie awake, I have become like a lonely bird on a housetop.
My enemies have **reproached** me all day long;
those who deride me have used my name as a curse.

Jesus is saying that living by his manifesto will likely result in them being persecuted by their fellow Israelites and the culture at large. The difficult circumstances will be painful and unpleasant (think of the early chapters of Acts of the Apostles), and so his disciples will constantly need to reframe such hardship. Persecution, Jesus says, is not a sign of divine disapproval—just the opposite. It is a sign of honor, showing that the message of Jesus’ Kingdom is confronting the powers and provoking a predictable response of hostility.

Notice how this blessing and the previous conflate “righteousness” and “on my account.” To follow Jesus and his Kingdom claims is “doing righteousness” that aligns with the will of God.

Notice also that here Jesus is anticipating the path that he himself will walk to the cross.

Chrysostum (*Homilies on Matthew*, 15.7) has a great line here:

"Lest you should think the mere fact having evil spoken of you makes you blessed, note the two limitations: when it is for his sake, and when the things said are false: for without these, the one who has evil spoken of them is, instead of being blessed, actually miserable."

Saint Chrysostom. [Homilies on Matthew](#).

"Persecution of the prophets": This places Jesus' statement in a long line of statements about Israel's persecution and rejection of the true prophets of Yahweh.

Summary of 7th-9th Beatitudes

How good is life for those who engage the conflicts that divide our world and our relationships, seeking and brokering peace in the midst of a hostile world. This will inevitably create misunderstanding that leads to ill-treatment and public dishonor. But this is a cause for deep joy because it means that the God of Israel is challenging the powers through his messianic people.

Summaries of the Beatitudes

"We can compare the work of the beatitudes to that of a plow in the fields. Drawn along with determination it drives the sharp wedge of the plowshare into the earth and carves out, as the poets say, a deep wound, a broad furrow. ... In the same way the beatitudes penetrate us ... in order to break up our interior soil. It cuts through us with the sharp edge of trials and with the struggles it provokes. It overturns our ideas and projects, reverses what seems obvious, thwarts our desires, and bewilders us, leaving us poor and naked before God. All this, in order to prepare a place within us for the seed of a new kind of life."

Pinckaers, Servais (2011). [Pursuit of Happiness](#). Wipf and Stock. 36-37.

Scot McKnight has a helpful way of making the Beatitudes stick in a modern context.

"I wonder if we should examine the standards used to measure people according to the 'Christian standard.' How should we measure piety, or spirituality, or true Christianity? Jesus measures it by the standard of whether a person loves God, loves self, and loves others. Look at who Jesus blesses here:

- those who are the humble poor
- those who pursue righteousness and justice
- those who create peace

His standard and our standard are often at odds. In my experience in churches, I see these sorts of standards to measure followers:

- those who read their Bible and pray daily
- those who attend church regularly
- those who tithe
- those who know a lot about the Bible
- those who preach well
- those who exercise the spiritual gifts
- those who exercise the spiritual disciplines

- those who evangelize
- those who have great stories of conversion
- those who write books, especially ones about Jesus
- those who separate themselves from the world
- those who have succeeded in business and fund Christian ministry
- those who run for public office

But here's the problem: By what standard do we measure these things as spiritually superior? ... Are these things the standard of evaluation that Jesus advocates? ... The Beatitudes of Jesus are nothing short of a revolution of evaluation. We see in those whom Jesus blesses those who truly are the Jesus people of this world."

Adapted from McKnight, Scot (2013). [*Sermon on the Mount \(The Story of God Bible Commentary\)*](#). Zondervan Academic.

Reflection Question

How would you describe the status and character of the people Jesus identifies as having the good life in the first six beatitudes?